

Children of a LESSER GOD

The top foodgrain producing state is also the one with the highest child malnutrition rate. The future is dark.

By Farzand Ahmed

It's a human tragedy of massive proportions that everyone seems aware of but is clueless about combating. In Uttar Pradesh, the country's most populous state and the only one currently to be run by a woman, women run the highest risk of maternal mortality. Last week, UNICEF came out with another devastating report which said the state is the "riskiest state" for babies, especially newborns and mothers.

In its 'State of the World's Children 2009' report, it has also termed the state "the riskiest place for a woman to have a baby in India. In Uttar Pradesh, a woman has a one in 42 lifetime risk of maternal death, compared to a probability of just one in 500 for women in Kerala". Only a week before UNICEF presented its report to Governor T.V. Rajeswar, Vice-President Hamid Ansari had curtly remarked at a function in Lucknow that "being born in Uttar Pradesh reduces one's lifespan by several years. It would seem that the state you are born into determines how long you would live". Quoting data produced by the National Family Health Survey 2005-06, the vice-president said: "Indeed the picture that has emerged is very distressing."

The UNICEF report highlights the link between maternal and neo-natal survival, and suggests opportunities

to close the gap between rich and poor countries. This is not the first report to paint a gloomy picture. Six months ago, the state Planning Department had brought out a first-ever report titled 'The State of Children in Uttar Pradesh'. That too made for depressing reading. The study, jointly conducted with UNICEF, revealed that 52 per cent of the state's children were severely malnourished while the all-India figure was 43. It also revealed that while the percentage of malnutrition among children was just 35 in the least developing world, the figure for sub-Saharan Africa was 28 per cent. South Asia as whole has a 42 per cent child malnutrition rate as against 26 per cent in developing countries.

Last year, when the Uttar Pradesh Government came out with a report stating the per capita income in the state had jumped by 4.03 per cent, two-year-old Shaheena Parveen, who weighed three kg, breathed her last. Days before she collapsed, her two-year-old neighbour, Sahabuddin, had died. Several other children in Dhannipur village in Varanasi await a similar fate. Suffering from malnutrition, most of them are children of weavers whose looms once churned out saris. Now out of work, they're unable to provide their children with proper meals. But Dhannipur is per-



haps just a microcosm of the entire state. Peoples' Vigilance Committee on Human Rights (PVCHR) quotes a state government survey to say that 540 children are still suffering from Grade III and Grade IV malnutrition. Last year, Bijo Francis of the Hong Kong-based Asian Human Rights Commission circulated a report worldwide saying, "When he (Sahabuddin) died, he weighed six kg. This is Grade III malnutrition (often